

أَعُوذُ بِاللَّهِ مِنَ الشَّيْطَانِ الرَّجِيمِ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Lisan ul Quran — Lecture 1

Harakaat · The difference between Hamzah and Alif · Huroof ul Hijaa'

1. Introduction: Gratitude, Intention and the Importance of Learning Arabic

Every branch of knowledge begins with gratitude to Allah, and the journey of learning the language of the Qur'an in particular should begin with the awareness that this opportunity is itself a gift from Him.

How gratitude is expressed

Allah has taught us the very words of gratitude in the Qur'an itself. In Surah al-A'raf He tells us what the people of Paradise will say upon entering it:

وَقَالُوا الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الَّذِي هَدَانَا لِهَذَا وَمَا كُنَّا لِنَهْتَدِيَ لَوْلَا أَنَّ هَدَانَا اللَّهُ

(Surah al-A'raf: 43)

Translation: All praise and all thanks belong to Allah, who guided us to this; and had Allah not guided us, we could never have found the way.

This verse teaches a great truth: real gratitude means acknowledging that whatever we have received is not the product of our own effort but the fruit of Allah's guidance and enabling. Being given the chance to learn the language of the Qur'an is itself part of that enabling.

Why learning Arabic matters

Allah Himself states the reason the Qur'an was revealed in Arabic:

إِنَّا أَنْزَلْنَاهُ قُرْآنًا عَرَبِيًّا لَعَلَّكُمْ تَعْقِلُونَ

(Surah Yusuf: 2)

Translation: Indeed We have revealed this Qur'an in Arabic so that you may understand.

The verse makes it plain that the Qur'an is not meant only to be recited but also to be understood. When Allah Himself says it was revealed to be understood, the idea that Arabic is too difficult loses its ground. What is needed is effort, and a prayer to Allah for steadfastness.

Why the Qur'an must be understood

Elsewhere Allah says:

وَلَقَدْ يَسَّرْنَا الْقُرْآنَ لِلذِّكْرِ فَهَلْ مِنْ مُدَكِّرٍ

[Surah al-Qamar: 17]

Translation: And We have certainly made the Qur'an easy for remembrance, so is there anyone who will take heed?

The question arises: how will one take heed from the Qur'an? If recitation continues but the meaning of the words is never known, genuine reflection cannot occur. This is why understanding the Qur'an is necessary in order to benefit from it.

Note: Shaytan puts the thought into a student's heart that Arabic is very difficult. Against this, one should keep in view those verses in which Allah Himself declares that the Qur'an has been made easy.

The beauty and range of Arabic

Arabic is a vast and highly ordered language. Behind every word, every sentence, and even every *harakah* there is a rule and a wisdom. This is precisely what makes it so engaging for a learner.

For an Urdu speaker Arabic is easier still, because roughly **eighty percent** of Urdu vocabulary has come from Arabic. In passing from one language to the other only the pronunciation or form changed slightly. Grasping that shift alone gives a learner familiarity with more than half of Arabic.

2. The meaning of Lisan ul Quran

Lisan in Arabic means **tongue or language**, and *Qur'an* refers to the Book of Allah. Joining the two gives لِسَانُ الْقُرْآنِ, meaning **the language of the Qur'an**.

Rule: Notice that Arabic has no separate word between these two nouns for the English **of**. Simply placing two nouns side by side produces that meaning automatically. This is one of the finest illustrations of the *fasahah* (eloquence) and *ikhtisar* (brevity) of Arabic.

Additional point: In *Nahw* terminology this pairing of two nouns is called a **Murakkab Idafi**. The first noun is the **Mudaf** and the second is the **Mudaf Ilayh**. In لِسَانُ الْقُرْآنِ, لِسَانُ is the **Mudaf** and الْقُرْآنِ is the **Mudaf Ilayh**. Later you will learn that the **Mudaf Ilayh** is always **Majroor**, which is why it is read here as الْقُرْآنِ.

3. Huroof ul Hijaa'

The most basic element of Arabic is the **Huroof ul Hijaa'** — what Urdu calls *huroof-e-tahajji* and English calls the alphabet. Just as a building cannot stand without bricks, the structure of Arabic cannot stand without recognising its letters.

The order of the letters

The letters are given below. This order matters because **entries in an Arabic dictionary follow it**. Without it in mind, looking up a word becomes difficult.

ا	ب	ت	ث	ج	ح	خ
د	ذ	ر	ز	س	ش	ص
ض	ط	ظ	ع	غ	ف	ق
ك	ل	م	ن	ه	و	ي

28 letters in total — read right to left, row by row

How the names of the letters are pronounced

A useful principle: **those letters whose Urdu names end in the sound of the English letter A are pronounced in Arabic ending on an alif**. So where Urdu says bay, tay, thay, Arabic says با، تا، ثا.

In Urdu	In Arabic	In Urdu	In Arabic
ب	با	ز	زا
ت	تا	ط	طا
ث	ثا	ظ	ظا
ح	حا	ف	فا
خ	خا	ه	ها
ر	را	ی	یا

The disagreement over the number of letters

The number of *Hurooful Hijaa'* is stated as **twenty-eight or twenty-nine**. The root of this disagreement among scholars is the *Hamzah*.

- Some count *Alif* and *Hamzah* as a single letter, in which case the total is 28.
- Others count *Alif* and *Hamzah* separately, in which case the total becomes 29.

The settled view: There is *ijma'* (consensus) among the scholars that the number of *Huroof ul Hijaa'* is **twenty-eight**. The distinction between *Alif* and *Hamzah* is therefore determined not by counting letters but by the presence of a *harakah*, as explained next.

4. The difference between Hamzah and Alif

This is the most important and the most commonly confused point of the whole lecture. Once grasped, it stays clear forever.

The basic rule: An *Alif* becomes a *Hamzah* the moment any one of the three *harakaat* (zabar, zer, pesh) or a *sukoon* is placed upon it. When the *Alif* carries neither a *harakah* nor a *sukoon*, it remains a pure *Alif*.

Form	Name
ا	Alif
أ إ ئ ؤ	Hamzah

An illustration

Consider the word **إِفْرَأْ**. The alif-shaped letters at its beginning and end are in fact *Hamzah*, not *Alif*. The reason is that the first carries a *kasrah* and the last carries a *sukoon*. Since both bear a mark, both are *Hamzah*.

Historical background: why dots and harakaat were added

The copies of the *Mushaf* prepared in the era of Uthman (may Allah be pleased with him) were entirely free of dots and *harakaat*, because the Arabs of that time could read them correctly through their natural command of the language.

But as the Islamic conquests widened, countless non-Arab lands came under Islam and Arabic mixed with other tongues. Reading the Qur'an without dots and *harakaat* became difficult for non-Arabs. For this reason dots and *harakaat* were added to the *Mushaf* so that everyone could recite it with ease.

Likewise the *Hamzah* was originally pronounced but not written. This is why most scholars agree that an *Alif* is called *Hamzah* once a *harakah* or a *sukoon* appears on it.

Recognising Hamzah in the Pakistani and Saudi Mushaf

The way a *Hamzah* is identified differs according to the script of the *Mushaf*, so a student needs to know this difference. Without it, the same word seen in two different *Masahif* can cause confusion.

In the Pakistani Mushaf

- The *Hamzah* is generally written in a clear, explicit form.
- Wherever a *Hamzah* occurs, a proper ء appears, or the *Hamzah* is plainly visible on the alif with its *harakah* or *sukoon*.
- Recognising it in this script is comparatively easy.

In the Saudi Mushaf

- The *Hamzah* is often written as a small ء above or below the alif.
- This small mark signals that the letter is a *Hamzah* and not an *Alif*.
- In some places a small ص-like sign also appears above the alif.

Clarification: That small ص-like sign above the alif in the Saudi *Mushaf* was in origin the *Hamzah* itself. When it was transferred into the shape of an alif, this mark was placed on it to preserve its identity. Its only purpose is to tell the reader that **what is read here is a Hamzah, not an Alif**.

The rules for writing Hamzah

The *Hamzah* does not have one fixed shape in Arabic; it is written in different forms. Its spelling depends on which letter it sits upon and which *harakah* it carries. In the Qur'an it generally appears in the following four forms.

Form	Name	Qur'anic examples
أ / إ	Hamzah on an Alif	إِفْرَأْ ، أَمَرَ
وُ	Hamzah on a Waw	يُؤْمِنُ
يْ	Hamzah on a Yaa'	سَيِّئِ
ء	Hamzah standing alone, on no letter	سَيِّءٌ

5. Harakaat

The second essential element of Arabic is the *harakaat*. These are the small marks placed above or below a letter to fix its sound. There are three basic *harakaat*:

Sign	Urdu name	Arabic name
َ	zabar	Fathah

Sign	Urdu name	Arabic name
◌ِ	zer	Kasrah
◌ُ	pesh	Dammah

Sukoon

Besides the *harakaat* there is another important sign, the **sukoon** ◌ْ. The *sukoon* is the opposite of a *harakah*: a *harakah* means movement, while *sukoon* means coming to rest. A letter bearing a *sukoon* is *sakin*, meaning no vowel sound is joined to it; it is pronounced together with the letter before it.

Tanween

A doubled *harakah* ◌ِ ◌ِ ◌ِ is called **Tanween** — two zabar, two pesh and two zer. In pronunciation a silent n sound is produced with the *Tanween*, so كِتَابٌ is read as kitabun.

Additional point: Two valuable points about *Tanween* are worth adding. First, *Tanween* is one of the *alamaat* of an *Ism*: if you see it at the end of a word, that word is an *Ism*, not a *Fi'l* or *Harf*. Second, the *Tanween* that comes at the end of a *Nakirah* is called **Harfut Tankeer**, and in Urdu it is usually rendered as "some" or "a certain" — so طِفْلٌ means "a child" and لَبَنٌ means "some milk".

Tashdeed

Another sign used in Arabic is the **Tashdeed** ◌ّ. An important point here: **Tashdeed is not a separate harakah**; it merely indicates that **the letter has occurred twice** — once *sakin* and once carrying a *harakah*.

The rule of Tashdeed: Where a *Tashdeed* appears, the **first occurrence of the letter is sakin** and the **second carries some harakah**. The two are then merged (*mudgham*) and a single *shaddah* is written over one letter.

This is best shown through the very du'a we recite at the end of a lesson:

Word	Original form, with the Tashdeed opened out
رَبِّ	رَ + بُ + بٍ
يَسِّرْ	يَ + سُنْ + سٍ + زُ

Word	Original form, with the Tashdeed opened out
تَعْسِرَ	ث + ع + س + س + ر

So in تَعْسِرَ the letter baa' has occurred **twice** — first *sakin* and then with a *kasrah* — and that is why a *shaddah* is written on it.

Madd

One further sign is the **Madd** َ. Its rule is simple: **a letter carrying a Madd is stretched when read.**

This sign matters particularly in *Tajweed*, since it fixes the length of the sound.

6. Standing harakaat and the difference between the two Masahif

In the Qur'an, and especially in the Pakistani *Mushaf*, one sees a standing zabar, a standing zer and an inverted pesh.

Important rule: The standing zabar, the standing zer and the inverted pesh are **not separate harakaat**; they are the **lengthened forms** of the basic three. That is why they are read longer than an ordinary zabar, zer or pesh.

Standing harakah	What it is really made of
Standing zabar َ	zabar + alif
Standing zer ِ	zer + yaa'
Inverted pesh ُ	pesh + waw

The difference between the Pakistani and Saudi Mushaf

Harakah	Pakistani Mushaf	Saudi Mushaf
Standing zabar	written as the sign َ	written out as zabar + alif
Standing zer	written as the sign ِ	written out as zer + full yaa'
Inverted pesh	written as the sign ُ	written out as pesh + waw

So if you are used to the Pakistani *Mushaf* and open a Saudi one, there is no cause for alarm — the reading is identical, only the manner of writing has changed.

Summary

1. The purpose of learning Arabic is to understand the Qur'an, and Allah Himself has declared that the Qur'an has been made easy for that purpose.
2. Roughly eighty percent of Urdu vocabulary comes from Arabic, which makes Arabic comparatively easy for an Urdu speaker.
3. In a construction such as Lisan ul Quran, Arabic has no separate word for "of"; two nouns placed together carry that meaning.
4. By consensus the number of Huroof ul Hijaa' is 28; the disagreement arises only from the Hamzah.
5. Letters whose Urdu names end in the A sound are pronounced in Arabic ending on an alif: baa, taa, thaa.
6. Once a harakah or a sukoon appears on an Alif, it becomes a Hamzah. Bare alif = Alif; alif with zabar, zer, pesh or sukoon = Hamzah.
7. Hamzah is written in four forms: ا, إ, ئ, ء.
8. There are three basic harakaat: Fathah (zabar), Kasrah (zer) and Dammah (pesh). Sukoon is their opposite.
9. A doubled harakah is called Tanween, and Tanween is also one of the marks of an Ism.
10. Tashdeed is not a harakah; it shows that a letter has occurred twice, first sakin and then carrying a harakah.
11. Standing zabar = zabar + alif; standing zer = zer + yaa'; inverted pesh = pesh + waw.
12. The Pakistani Mushaf writes these as signs while the Saudi Mushaf writes them out in full; the recitation is the same in both.

Exercise

1. Why do scholars differ over the number of Huroof ul Hijaa', and on which number is there consensus?
2. How many Hamzahs are there in the word اِقْرَأْ, and why? Give the reason for each separately.
3. Open out the Tashdeed in each of the following: رَبِّ, يَسِّرْ, تُعَسِّرْ.
4. What are the standing zabar, standing zer and inverted pesh really composed of, and how are they written in the Saudi Mushaf?
5. Write out all four forms of the Hamzah, each with a Qur'anic example.
6. Explain the difference between Alif and Hamzah with an example.
7. Describe how the Hamzah is written differently in the Pakistani and Saudi Mushaf.
8. What is Tanween and how is it pronounced?

اَللّٰهُمَّ صَلِّ عَلٰى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلٰى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا صَلَّيْتَ عَلٰى اِبْرَاهِيْمَ وَعَلٰى آلِ اِبْرَاهِيْمَ اِنَّكَ حَمِيْدٌ مُّجِيْدٌ

اَللّٰهُمَّ بَارِكْ عَلٰى مُحَمَّدٍ وَعَلٰى آلِ مُحَمَّدٍ كَمَا بَارَكْتَ عَلٰى اِبْرَاهِيْمَ وَعَلٰى آلِ اِبْرَاهِيْمَ اِنَّكَ حَمِيْدٌ مُّجِيْدٌ